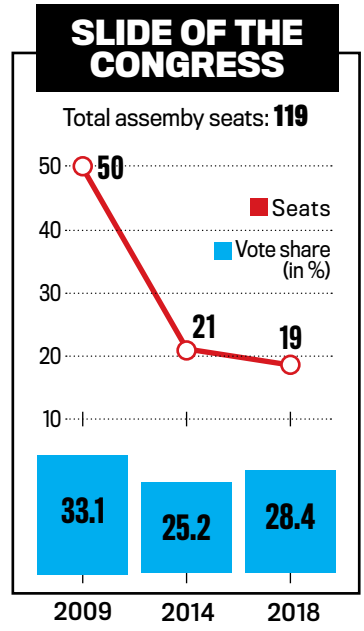
dustrialist who left the Congress barely a year ago, resigned from the Munugode seat, briefly joined the BJP and lost in an election there—is back in the Congress, and is to contest the same seat. Among the others who have come from the BRS is sitting MLA M. Hanumantha Rao, who declined a party ticket because his son did not get one.

The Congress is making a determined effort to change the perception of KCR as a formidable rival. Revanth Reddy will challenge the BRS chief in Kamareddy, in addition to running in his home constituency, Kodangal. This is taking a cue from the BJP—Eatala Rajender, a former BRS finance minister, is taking on KCR in his original constituency Gajwel, besides his native Huzurabad. Revanth asserts, "What KCR has done is not what the people of Telangana had wished for, but rather for his family." The campaign also delves into a nuanced targeting of KCR's larger-than-life image and his story of struggle and sacrifice for Telangana's separate statehood. "KCR and his family went to Sonia Gandhi's home, touched her feet, took photographs and deceived her the next day," recalls AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge about what the BRS chief did in 2014.



"WHAT KCR HAS DONE IS NOT WHAT THE PEOPLE OF TELANGANA HAD WISHED FOR, BUT RATHER FOR HIS FAMILY"

REVANTH REDDY
President, Telangana Congress

What goes in its favour is a certain domino effect of its Karnataka triumph, its Six Guarantees, and the two-term anti-incumbency plaguing the BRS. However, problems related to ticket distribution may play spoiler in several seats. To prevent desertions and project a united front, several leaders have collaborated on bus yatras to select constituencies with visits of the Gandhi siblings—Rahul and Priyanka—thrown in, particularly to publicly welcome new entrants.

But welfarism is still central to its vocabulary. After kicking off the campaign with the first meeting of the newly constituted Congress Working Committee in Hyderabad, Sonia Gandhi unveiled the Six Guarantees at a big rally on September 17. Analysts feel the party's commitment to implementing these within the first 100 days of assuming power has given it a boost. "This has enthused the cadre, creating a perceptible change in mood. Such mobilisation can work wonders if the promises are conveyed effectively to the voters," says E. Venkatesu of the University of Hyderabad. But, he points out, "the failure to keep Rahul's promise of providing two tickets to BCs in every Lok Sabha constituency (totalling 34) is an issue."

And for all the talk of a repeat of Karnataka's blanket Muslim backing, the Congress is facing flak from that quarter too. Shaik Abdullah Sohail, who quit as chairman of the Congress's local minorities department, now vows to help KCR win against a party consumed by RSS-style "communalisation". He also alleges "sale of tickets" to outsiders and criticises the Congress for ignoring those like the party's BC department chairman Nuthi Srikanth Goud. Others, however, argue that an overriding factor in favour of the party lies in KCR's failure to fulfil its promise of providing 12 per cent reservation for minorities in education and employment, and the BJP's promise to scrap the existing minority quota altogether and allocate it to the BCs instead.

But the bus yatras are seeing a surge of action built around the theme of citizen-centric governance: a grievance collection campaign, suggestion boxes at all party offices in every district, a toll-free number, a website to channel complaints all the way to a new Grievance Redressal Ministry. The buzz is worrisome for KCR. In his aggressive campaigning, with rallies in two to three constituencies every day, he warns of power blackouts and the scrapping of welfare schemes, including the Rythu Bandhu scheme, if the Congress is elected. "Personally, we don't lose anything. If you defeat us, we will take a rest. But you will lose. As the one who fought for and achieved Telangana, it is my responsibility to tell you, to guide Telangana in the right way," he declared the other day at Achampet.

The BRS will use all the tricks at its command, but anti-incumbency, unemployment, corruption and other markers of irresponsible governance, besides centralisation of authority and the urge to annihilate the Opposition, may prove to be its nemesis. In a tough election for both parties, both grand rhetoric and micro factors will play a role. "A substantial section of Dalits and Muslims, a considerable percentage of Reddys and other dominant castes, plus a large segment of young voters, may go with the Congress if it manages its campaign well," says Vageeshan. The determinant may be those who will not. ■